

# The Giant of Bern and Orm Ungerswayne: A Ballad

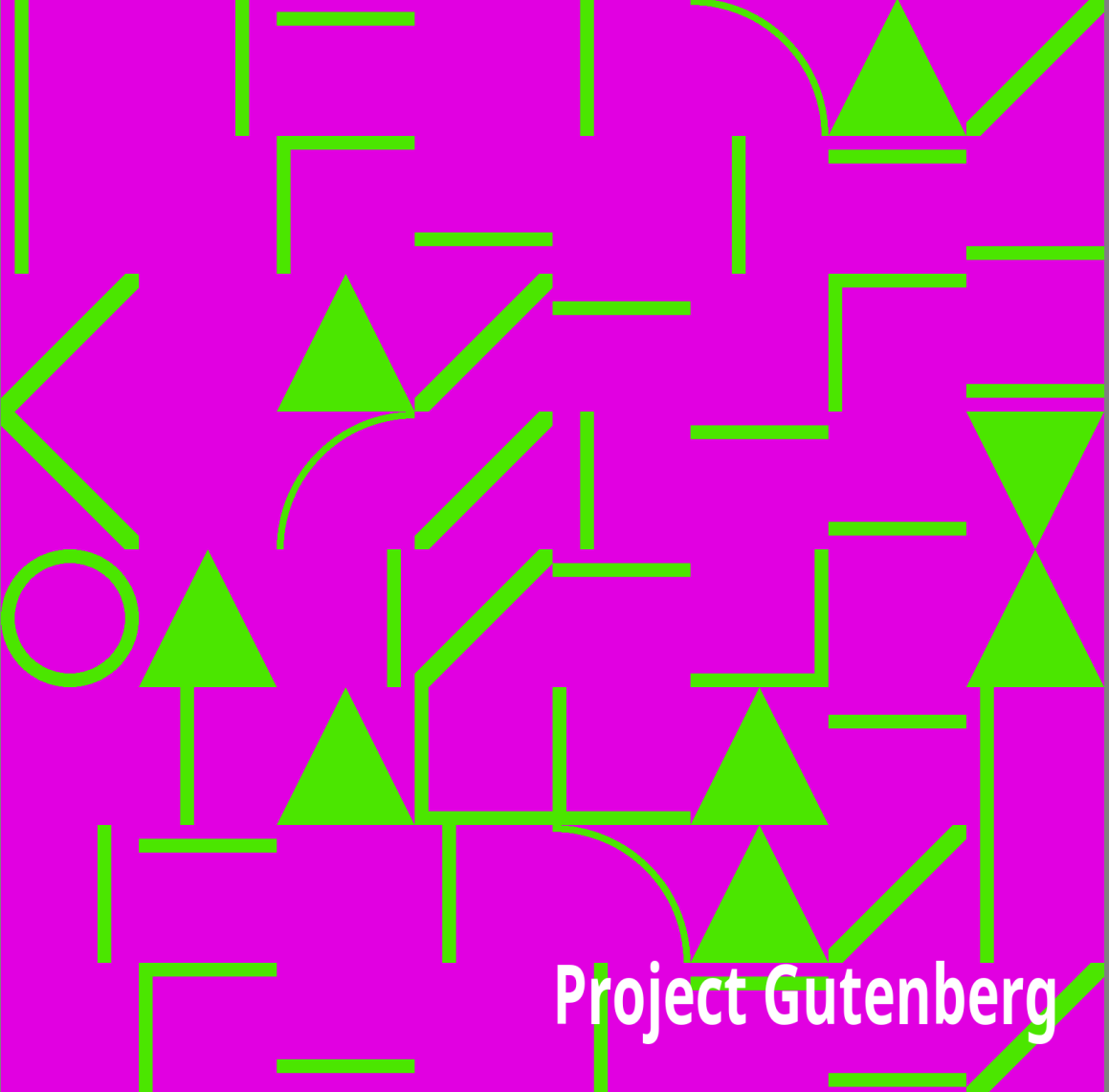
George Borrow and Thomas James Wise



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Title: The Giant of Bern and Orm Ungerswayne: A Ballad

Author: George Borrow

Editor: Thomas James Wise

Release date: May 14, 2009 [eBook #28818]

Language: English

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# **THE GIANT OF BERN AND ORM UNGERSWAYNE**

## **A BALLAD**

BY  
GEORGE BORROW

LONDON:  
PRINTED FOR PRIVATE CIRCULATION  
1913

## THE GIANT OF BERN AND ORM UNGERSWAYNE

It was the lofty Jutt of Bern  
O'er all the walls he grew;  
He was mad and ne'er at rest,  
To tame him no one knew.

He was mad and ne'er at rest,  
No lord could hold him in;  
If he had long in Denmark stayed  
Much damage there had been.

It was the lofty Jutt of Bern  
Bound to his side his glaive,  
And away to the monarch's house he rode  
With the knights a fray to have.

Now goes the lofty Jutt of Bern  
Before the King to stand:  
"Thou shalt to me thy daughter give,  
And a brief for half thy land.

"Here as thou sitt'st at thy wide board,  
Hail Monarch of the Danes!  
Thou shalt to me thy daughter give,  
And the half of thy domains.

"Thou shalt to me thy daughter give,  
And divide with me thy land,  
Or thou shalt find a kempion good  
In the ring 'gainst me to stand."

“O thou shalt ne’er my daughter get,  
Nor a brief for half my land,  
I’ll quickly find a kempion good  
Shall fight thee hand to hand.”

Then strode the Monarch of the Danes  
To his castle hall amain:  
“Now which of ye, my courtiers, will  
The lovely Damsel gain?

“Here sit ye all my Danish swains  
On whom I bread bestow,  
Now which of ye will risk his life  
To lay the Berner low?

“I’ll give to him my daughter dear,  
The wondrous lovely may,  
Who in the ring with Jutt of Bern  
Shall dare the desperate fray.”

In silence all the kempions sat,  
None dared reply a word,  
Except alone Orm Ungerswayne,  
The lowest at the board.

Except alone Orm Ungerswayne,  
He bounded o’er the board:  
I tell to ye in verity  
He spake a manly word.

“Wilt thou to me thy daughter give,  
And divide with me thy land?  
O then will I the kempion be,  
Against the Jutt to stand.

“And well will I your daughter win,  
And the prize alone will earn;  
I am the lad to dare the fray  
In the ring with the Jutt of Bern.”

It was the lofty Jutt of Bern  
He o'er his shoulder glar'd:  
"O who may yonder mouseling be,  
From whom those words I heard?"

"No mouseling I, though call me, Jutt,  
A mouseling if you will,  
My father was good Sigurd King  
Who slumbers in his hill."

"Ha! was thy sire good Sigurd King?  
Thou'st something of his face,  
Thou hast sprung up full wondrously  
In fifteen winter's space."

It was so late at evening tide  
The sun had reached the wave,  
When Orm the youthful swain set out  
To seek his father's grave.

It was the hour when grooms do ride  
The coursers to the rill,  
That Orm set out resolved to wake  
The dead man in the hill.

Now strikes the bold Orm Ungerswayne  
The hill with such a might,  
It was I ween a miracle  
It tumbled not outright.

Then stamped upon the hill so hard  
Young Orm with heavy foot,  
The arch was broke within the hill  
Which trembled to its root.

Then from the hill Orm's father cried,  
Where he so long had lain:  
"O cannot I in quiet lie  
Within my murky den?"

“Who dares so early break my rest,  
And troubleth thus my bones?  
Cannot I in quiet lie  
Beneath my roof of stones?”

“Who seeks at night the dead man’s hill  
And works this ruin all?  
Let him fear for now I swear  
By Birting he shall fall.”

“I am thy son, thy youngest son,  
Thy Orm, O father dear;  
To beg a boon in mighty need  
I come to seek thee here.”

“If thou art Orm my youngest son,  
The kempion bold and brave,  
Last year I gave to thee of gold,  
All, all thy heart could crave.”

“Last year you gave me store of gold  
On which I set no worth,  
Now I this year must Birting have,  
The bravest sword on earth.”

“Never shalt thou Birting get  
To win the Monarch’s daughter,  
Until to Ireland thou hast been  
To ’venge thy father’s slaughter.”

“Give to me the Birting sword,  
And with it bid me thrive,  
Or I the hill above thee will  
To thousand pieces rive.”

“Stretch thou down thy hand and take  
My Birting from my side,  
But if thou break thy father’s hill  
Much woe will thee betide.”

He cast to him the sword, its point  
    Appeared above the mould:  
“Save good fate on thee shall wait  
    I ne’er shall be consol’d.”

He reached to him the sword, and placed  
    Its hilt within his grasp:  
“Beneath its blows may all thy foes  
    Before thee sink and grasp.”

Then took the sword Orm Ungerswayne,  
    And on his shoulder plac’d;  
And to the Monarch’s hall he sped,  
    As fast as he could haste.

It was the lofty Jutt of Bern  
    With wrath was nearly wild:  
“It ill becomes a man like me  
    To battle with a child.”

“Although I be but little, Jutt,  
    A fearless heart I keep,  
And oftentimes a little hand  
    O’erturns a mighty heap.”

For two long days they fought, and when  
    The third to evening tended,  
“Methinks,” exclaim’d the Berner Jutt,  
    “This fight will ne’er be ended.”

It was bold Orm Ungerswayne  
    His good sword brandish’d he,  
And of the lofty Berner Jutt  
    Asunder cut the knee.

Loud bellowed then the Berner Jutt,  
    And loud he fell to ban:  
“It ne’er was warrior custom yet  
    So low to strike one’s man.”

“I was small, and thou wast tall,  
Thy prowess I admire;  
I only struck thy knee because  
I could not reach thee higher.”

Then took the bold Orm Ungerswayne  
His faulchion on his back,  
And to the ocean strand he goes  
As fast as he could make.

It was bold Orm Ungerswayne  
He paced the yellow sand,  
And lo! Sir Tord of Valland came  
Swift sailing to the land.

Foremost upon the gilded prow  
The Tord of Valland stands:  
“O who is yonder little man  
That walks upon the sands?”

“O I am Orm, the youthful swain,  
A kempion bold and fine;  
'Twas I that slew the Berner Jutt,  
That uncle dear of thine.”

“If thou hast slain the Berner Jutt,  
That uncle dear of mine,  
'Twas I the King of Ireland slew,  
Beloved father thine.”

It was Tord of Valland then  
With faulchion struck the earth:  
“Never will I make amends  
By gold or money's worth.”

It was bold Orm Ungerswayne,  
He grasped his faulchion's hilt:  
“In vengeance for my father then  
Shall valiant blood be spilt.”

It was the bold Orm Ungerswayne  
He drew his trusty sword,  
And at a single blow smote off  
The head of Valland's Tord.

Valland's Tord he slew, and then  
His followers every one;  
Then speeds he to the monarch's house  
To claim the maid he'd won.

Then took the bold Orm Ungerswayne  
The Atheling in his arm:  
"Thou art my own, fair maid, for thee  
I have confronted harm."

O'er Helmer Isle the tidings run  
As fast as levin fire,  
That Orm the lovely maid has won,  
And has avenged his sire.

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LONDON:  
Printed for THOMAS J. WISE, Hampstead, N.W.  
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